

THE INDIE ERA

BEHOLD!

For independently developed by small teams, games from no-name studios are finally not just outnumbering big studios and AAA titles... they're outclassing them, too

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The term indie has been popping up all over the place these days. It's become quite huge for that matter. There's people calling it the Indie Revolution and the Indie Movement and whatnot. But first, let's ask ourselves the most basic question. What exactly is an indie?

Well, in theory indie stands for independent, so studios or companies who are not owned by a publisher would technically fall under this category. But in that case, companies like Valve and Gearbox would fall under this category too. They aren't owned by any publishers and they pretty much do what they want. But we don't consider them indie, nah they're way too big. A company like Telltale for example, might have started off indie but they've increased in size tenfold since their success and they have 150+ member studios who work on licensed games. Doesn't look very indie to us at the moment. Then of

course there's games like Journey. Definitely looks and feels indie, heck we totally thought it was an indie game till we started writing this article. Turns out Journey was part of publishing deals with major players so no, not very indie either to begin with, eh?.

So then finally what do we consider indie? Well we're looking at small studios where there's only like one or two people. A skeleton crew if you will, who do not care for the whims of publishers or licenses and all that. They're not tied down by anything so to speak. The games these guys make, is what to us, define an indie game.

Why are Indies so successful? Is there a lesson for AAA titles here?

Now it wouldn't be right to just straight up say that indies are more successful than your standard AAA title. A title by a AAA developer and publisher is expected to make well over \$5 million. There are many factors that come into play

here. It's incredibly rare to find an indie game with the same production quality as a AAA game. Which makes sense, considering a AAA company has much deeper pockets, larger teams, infrastructure, all that. Furthermore, there are many indie games being dished out every other day. A much larger number when compared to the number of games released by AAA companies. It's much more difficult to find the good indie games among the thousands of releases than it is to spot a good AAA among the few that release every year.

But despite all this we find ourselves gravitating towards indie games. Why is this so? It's quite simple really. It's not that we're boycotting AAA companies and standing up for the little man (sure that's nice too) but it's because indie games are giving us what we want. Over the past few years all we seemed to be getting from AAA companies was rehashed and recycled goods. The name of the game is money, demand